

PiperABM: A Python Library for Resilience-Based Agent Modeling

Aslan Noorghasemi¹, Sierra Hicks², and Christopher McComb¹

¹ Department of Mechanical Engineering, Carnegie Mellon University, USA ² Department of Natural Resources and the Environment, Cornell University, USA Corresponding author

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Summary

PiperABM is an open-source Python library for building agent-based simulations that couple human behavior with degrading infrastructure on real-world geospatial layouts. It provides lightweight primitives to enable agents with a customizable decision loop, infrastructure with spatial graphs whose effective travel costs evolve, and built-in analysis for accessibility to resources and travel distance, plus optional animation. Because it is implemented with familiar scientific tools like NumPy and NetworkX, researchers can inspect and extend models directly, integrate empirical data, and reuse standard workflows. *PiperABM* targets research questions centered on resilience, where people's choices and infrastructure conditions co-evolve, seeking to reduce the setup overhead typical of one-off models while remaining flexible enough for diverse hazards, places, and policies.

Statement of Need

Agent-based models (ABMs) represent systems “from the bottom up” using heterogeneous, interacting agents whose local rules and behaviors generate macro-level patterns (Joshua M. Epstein, 1999; Joshua M. Epstein & Axtell, 1996; Schelling, 2006). ABM has also been highlighted as a framework that engages diverse stakeholders, enables the forecasting of equitable futures, and empowers policy (Hicks et al., 2021; Noorghasemi, Xiao, & McComb, 2025). Over recent decades, ABM has matured into a practical research method supported by the scientific Python ecosystem (Hoeven et al., 2025). This paradigm is well-suited to infrastructure and community resilience, particularly within the Food–Energy–Water (FEW) nexus, where access to essential resources depends on both physical networks and human decisions, and where nonlinear feedbacks, thresholds, and cascades are common (Cansino-Loeza et al., 2022; Noorghasemi, Xiao, Sha, et al., 2025; Xue et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2019).

Resilience studies pose several practical modeling needs that are not well served by ad hoc scripts or purely equation-based approaches:

- Partial service levels and progressive degradation:** Models should represent graded performance (e.g., rougher roads increasing cost/time) rather than only binary failure, reflecting well-studied pavement deterioration processes and performance impacts, e.g., IRI-based assessments (Altarabsheh et al., 2021; Llopis-Castelló et al., 2024).
- Two-way coupling of behavior and infrastructure:** People adapt routes, priorities, and exchanges as networks evolve; these adaptations, in turn, load and degrade networks. Coupled human–infrastructure ABMs have demonstrated such feedbacks in flood-risk systems and related reviews emphasize capturing co-evolution (Anshuka et al., 2022; Michaelis et al., 2020).
- Real geospatial layouts for place-based analysis:** Integrating GIS data (maps/satellite-derived inputs) enables site-specific scenarios and stakeholder communication; recent

work in the Python ABM ecosystem formalizes GIS ingestion and spatial operations for ABMs (Wang et al., 2022).

- **Ensemble experiments and reproducibility:** Parameter sweeps, stochastic replications, and uncertainty and sensitivity analysis require clear, standardized reporting and careful data handling; community guidelines for documenting agent-based models and recent work on calibration and sensitivity analysis support replicable workflows (Grimm et al., 2020; McCulloch et al., 2022; Razavi et al., 2021).
- **Custom metrics and analysis pipelines:** Familiar data structures expose model state for domain-specific metrics, such as spatiotemporal accessibility under disruption (Enderami et al., 2024; Tariverdi et al., 2023).

PiperABM is built to address these needs and reduce the setup effort required for place-based resilience studies.

Intended users are researchers and practitioners in infrastructure and community resilience, including urban planners, policymakers, and decision-makers who need transparent, reproducible, place-based simulations.

Model Overview

PiperABM provides a baseline set of behavioral mechanisms and simple building blocks in pure Python: a society network comprised of agents and their relationships; an infrastructure network that can wear down over time; tools to load real maps; built-in measures such as accessibility and travel distance; and optional animation for evaluating face validity. With these pieces, researchers can quickly pose parameter-driven hypotheses, run “what-if” scenarios, and study how people’s choices and infrastructure co-evolve under the current behavioral assumptions, while more advanced behavioral mechanisms can be introduced through user-defined extensions.

At each time step, agents follow OODA-style decision logic: observing current conditions, orienting, deciding, and acting (Brehmer, 2005; Johnson, 2023). Agents choose actions such as where to travel, whom to meet, and whether to trade. Routing between locations uses an A* search on the evolving network to approximate human-like paths (Foead et al., 2021). Trades between agents are resolved using a Nash bargaining formulation (Nash, 1950), representing a cooperative, centralized mechanism in the current implementation. Infrastructure elements degrade due to both exogenous aging and endogenous usage by agents, increasing effective travel cost and feeding back into subsequent decisions. Simulation results are stored using human-readable delta differencing (KeepDelta), which is compact and easy to debug (Noorghasemi & McComb, 2025).

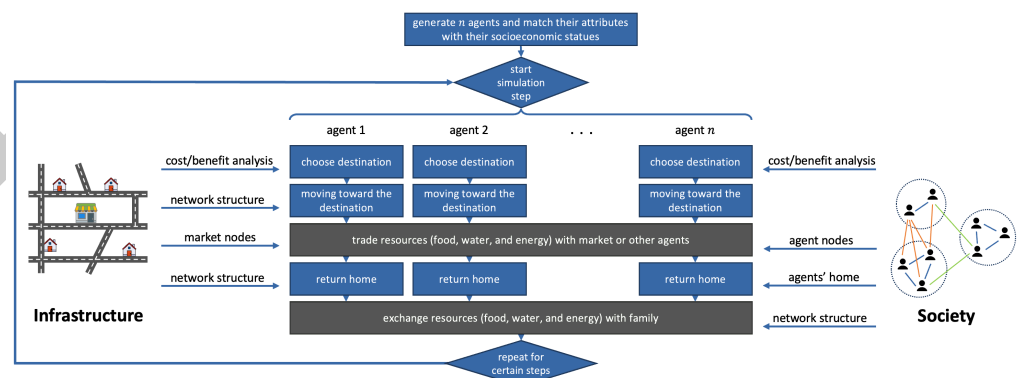


Figure 1. The computational model of PiperABM emulates the relation between the elements of infrastructure and social networks.

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